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US Communications Equipment

2Q26 Earnings Preview: Investor Focus on Supply Constraints

CITI'S TAKE

We remain constructive on multi-year networking infrastructure growth driven by AI with focus on “stage 4” or early adoption of scale up optics with NPO and CPO (see Figure 1). Our top buy-rated picks into earnings are LITE, KEYS, & CIEN and least preferred pick is CLS. Our stock rankings are influenced by the impact of constrained supply environments, especially silicon/lasers, and impact to the overall gross margins (see Figure 2).

Big Five Hyperscale 2026 Capex — The outlook for aggregate FY26 Big Five cloud data center capex has moved meaningfully higher (+16%) compared to April expectations with Citi estimates for 3 of the big 5 revised higher. Current Citi analysts’ projections point to aggregate data center capex growth of > 80% Y/Y in 2026 and more than 30% Y/Y in 2027. Ahead of Q2 reporting, four of the big five cloud SPs are expected to see an acceleration in 2026 data center capex growth vs 2025, according to Citi estimates compared to just one (Google) into Q1 results. In addition, three of the big five are now forecasted to grow 2026 capex above their two-year average growth rate, enough to shift the group on aggregate. As a result, we view the current capex environment as incrementally more positive for our networking coverage. Within our networking coverage: CLS’s top 3 customers, GOOGL, META, and AMZN, were 58% of FY25 sales; ANET’s top 2 customers were MSFT and META at 42% of FY25 sales; 2 hyperscalers were >30% of CIEN’s Apr-Q sales.

Front End Switch — Q1 26 front end data center switch market grew by mid 20s% Y/Y, per Dell’Oro, ahead of their expectations. Their FY26 outlook was raised to mid-teens growth Y/Y due to increasing prices, higher growth related to AI front end, and infrastructure investments ahead of AI deployments. ANET remained the market leader followed by CSCO.

AI Back-End switch — Q1’26 Ethernet back-end switch market was up more than 100% Y/Y and reached >\$3.7B, according to Dell’Oro. The market is on track to double Y/Y in 2026. CLS led in 1Q, followed by NVDA, ANET, white box and CSCO.

Campus Switch — Q1 campus switch market grew mid-teens Y/Y on volume and price increases, according to Dell’Oro. CSCO maintained its >50% share while ANET switch sales grew >20% Y/Y for the 2nd consecutive Q, resulting in ~3% share.

Optical Transport — Q1 optical transport market grew 20% Y/Y, according to Dell’Oro reflecting high teens growth in optical transport systems and >30% growth in ZR/ZR+. CIEN led the market with >25% share, up more than 300bps Y/Y, while CSCO was #5 with MSD share, up 200bps Y/Y.

Celestica (CLS) will be the first in our coverage to report 2Q26, on July 27.

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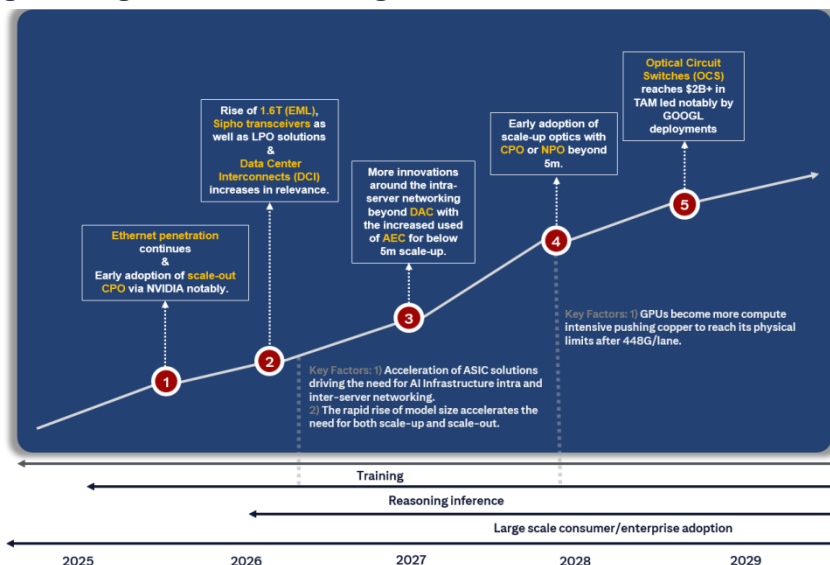
See Appendix A-1 for Analyst Certification, Important Disclosures and Research Analyst Affiliations.

2Q26 Earnings Preview

1. Citi's AI Infrastructure Playbook
2. Stock Rankings
3. Citi Cloud AI Capex Model
4. Key End markets

1. Citi's AI Infrastructure Playbook

Figure 1. Stages of AI - Focus on Stage 4



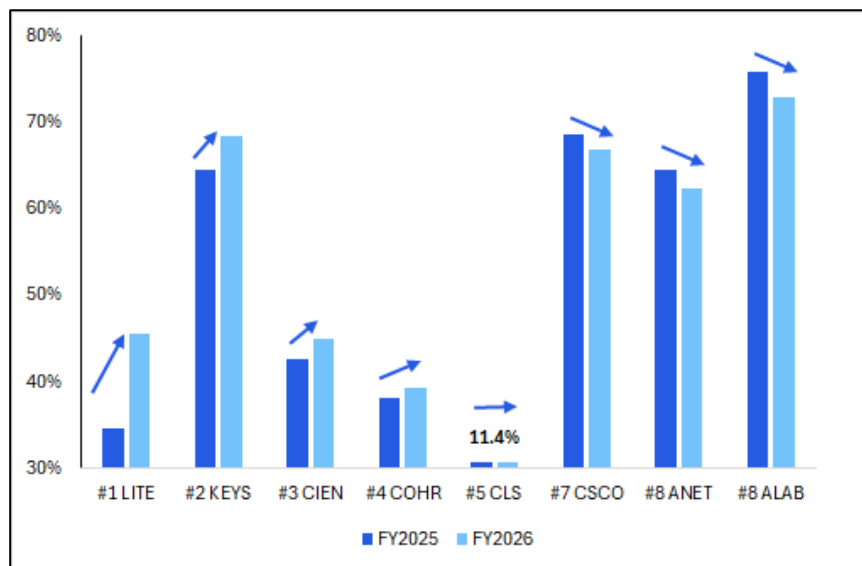
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Source: Citi Research

- Citi's AI infrastructure playbook divides networking into five stages. Following InfiniBand to Ethernet adoption, acceleration of ASIC solutions driving the need for intra and inter server networking, and data center interconnect stages, we are focused on "stage 4" or early adoption of scale up optics with NPO or CPO.

2. Stock Rankings

Figure 2. Citi Relative Stock Rankings (Highest to Lowest Y/Y Gross Margins)



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Source: Citi Research

- We continue to expect supply shortages, including silicon switches, memory, and lasers to impact the networking equipment supply chain negatively in 2H26. Our relative stock rankings are influenced by a) our concerns on the impact of the above component shortages, product mix, and the indirect impact to the gross margins, and b) exposure to “stage 4” to drive above average hyperscale capex growth in 2026.

3. Citi Cloud Data Center Capex

Figure 3. Big 5 Cloud Capex

\$ millions	2024	2025	2026E	2027E	2028E
AWS	53,436	90,080	154,689	197,231	243,897
Meta Compute	39,225	72,215	138,847	171,460	204,626
GSP	52,535	91,447	188,080	254,532	319,668
Azure	67,746	108,836	179,428	269,781	300,879
OCI	10,241	37,637	69,881	85,083	91,340
Big Five US	\$223,183	\$400,215	\$730,926	\$978,087	\$1,160,410
Year-over-Year (%)	70%	79%	83%	34%	19%

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Source: Citi Research, Company Reports

Figure 4. Growth outlook for Big Five Cloud Capex

Capex Y/Y %	2024	2025	2026E
AWS	70%	69%	72%
Meta Compute	40%	84%	92%
GSP	63%	74%	106%
Azure	97%	61%	65%
OCI	112%	268%	86%
Big Five US	70%	79%	83%

Capex Y/Y %	2024	2025	2026E	AVG (3yr)
AWS	70%	69%	72%	70%
Meta Compute	40%	84%	92%	72%
GSP	63%	74%	106%	81%
Azure	97%	61%	65%	74%
OCI	112%	268%	86%	155%
Big Five US	70%	79%	83%	77%

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Source: Citi Research, Company Reports

- The outlook for aggregate FY26 Big Five cloud data center capex has moved meaningfully higher (+16%) compared to expectations in April with Citi estimates for META, MSFT, and AMZN revised higher. We note current Citi analysts' projections point to aggregate data center capex growth of > 80% Y/Y in 2026 and more than 30% growth in 2027.
- Ahead of Q2 reporting, four of the big five cloud SPs are expected to see an acceleration in 2026 data center capex growth vs 2025, according to Citi estimates compared to just one (Google) into Q1 results. In addition, three of the big five are now forecasted to grow 2026 capex above their two-year average growth rate, enough to shift the group in aggregate. As a result, we view the current capex environment as incrementally more positive for our networking coverage.
- Within our networking coverage, CLS's top three customers are GOOGL, META, and AMZN at 58% of FY25 sales and ANET's top two customers are MSFT and META at 42% of FY25 sales. In CIEN's April-Q, two hyperscalers accounted for just over one-third of sales.

4. Key End Markets

Data center – Front end switch

- Q1 26 front end data center switch market grew by mid-20s% Y/Y, ahead of Dell'Oro's low-teens expectations.
- Dell'Oro's outlook for 2026 was raised from mid-single digit to mid-teens growth Y/Y due to increasing prices, higher growth related to AI front end, and infrastructure investments ahead of AI deployments.
- In the Q, top 4 cloud grew by >50% Y/Y and accounted for nearly 1/3 of the market; all cloud segments (top 4, top 3 China, tier 2, rest of cloud) combined grew by >40% Y/Y and were more than 50% of the front-end data center switch market.
- Large enterprise segment grew slower than the overall market and made up just over 1/3rd of the market.

- 400G accounted for mid-40s% of the market by sales while 800G was mid-single digits share of the market.
- ANET remained the top vendor in the market with nearly 3pt lead over #2 CSCO due to its strong position with cloud customers; ANET had nearly 1/3 of the top 4 cloud SP segment, nearly 8pts ahead of the next largest vendor. ANET was the 2nd largest provider to large enterprises and gained modest share in the quarter. 800G accounted for mid-teens % of ANET's mix.
- CSCO saw strong growth with cloud customers, where it gained nearly 3pts of share but remained the 5th largest cloud vendor, driven mostly by gains in the rest of cloud segment followed by top 4 cloud. Enterprise sales still account for >70% of CSCO's data center switch sales
- CLS was the fifth vendor in the market with mid-teens share, essentially flat Y/Y. With top 4 cloud SPs the company was edged out of 2nd place to 3rd by Accton. 800G accounted for low-teens % of CLS's quarterly mix.
- Dell'Oro is now reporting Accton separately from the other white box category. Accton is the 3rd largest player in the market and gained 3pts of share Y/Y.

Data center – AI back-end switch

- According to Dell'Oro, Q1'26 Ethernet back-end switch market was up more than 100% Y/Y and reached >\$3.7B.
- The InfiniBand back-end switch segment grew by >200% Y/Y to >\$2B.
- The Ethernet back-end switch market is on track to more than double Y/Y in 2026 to nearly \$22B.
- 800G made up approximately 80% of Ethernet sales (~70% of ports.)
- 1.6T was less than 1% of the market and remains in pre-production, but Dell'Oro expects a ramp in 2H with shipments initially to Amazon and Google then in 1H27 to Meta with CPO.
- CLS was the top vendor in the quarter with >25% share due to its positioning with top 4 cloud customers, which as a segment is over half of the market. However, CLS did lose ~5pts Y/Y in overall share, reflecting meaningful share loss in top 4 cloud, mostly to CSCO. CLS is the only vendor shipping 1.6T, although in very small sampling volumes.
- NVDA #2 player with mid-20s% share. Dell'Oro notes they plan to start shipping CPO on Spectrum-X in 2H.
- ANET was the third largest vendor in Q1 with low teens share and CSCO ranked 5th with high single digits share.
- CSCO wasn't in the market a year ago but was the 5th vendor in the Q1 market with ~8% overall share and ~13% with top 4 cloud customers. Cisco's growth is largely tied to Meta deployments, according to Dell'Oro.

Campus Switch

- Dell'Oro estimates the 1Q campus switch market grew mid-teens Y/Y to ~\$5B, reflecting volume and price increases.

- Increasing ASPs and extending lead times are expected to weigh on volumes over the balance of the year with Dell'Oro currently anticipating MSD growth Y/Y in 2026.
- CSCO remained the leading vendor with over 50% share that was essentially unchanged Y/Y.
- HPE was the #2 player in the market with low teens share, which was flat Y/Y adjusted for JNPR. Huawei was the third largest vendor in the market with high single digits share (essentially flat Y/Y).
- ANET remained the 6th ranked vendor with just over 3% market share but saw its campus switch sales grow by more than 20% Y/Y for the second consecutive quarter.

Optical Transport

- Q1 optical transport market grew by 20% Y/Y to >\$4B, according to Dell'Oro.
- Transport systems grew by high teens Y/Y.
- ZR/ZR+ pluggable revenues were up high 30s% Y/Y.
- Cloud customers accounted for over one-third of the market, with quarterly revenues up ~50% Y/Y.
- Declines in the China market, due to a pivot in compute infrastructure to traditional telecom infrastructure, is amplifying typical weak seasonality for Huawei and ZTE.
- CIEN was the top vendor in the market with >25% share and revenues grew by nearly 40% Y/Y due to its strong positioning with cloud SPs. CIEN gained 100bps of share in both ZR/ZR+ pluggables and DCI applications.
- NOK was the 3rd largest vendor. While Q1 is seasonally weaker for NOK, sales grew >20% Y/Y and the company gained ~100bps, adjusted for Infinera in the prior period, due to demand from traditional carriers.
- CSCO sales grew by high 80s% Y/Y on higher cloud SP sales. The company gained >200bps of share and was the 5th ranked vendor in the market. Acacia had the highest share in pluggables based on shipments for both 400 ZR/ZR+ and 800 ZR/ZR+.
- Dell'Oro raised its FY26 outlook from +10% to mid-teens % Y/Y growth.

Companies Mentioned:

Arista Networks (ANET.N; US\$171.92; 1; 15 Jul 26; 16:00) | Astera Labs, Inc (ALAB.O; US\$350.62; 1; 15 Jul 26; 16:00) | Celestica (CLS.N; US\$334.77; 1; 15 Jul 26; 16:00) | Ciena (CIEN.K; US\$418.46; 1; 15 Jul 26; 16:00) | Cisco Systems (CSCO.O; US\$111.77; 1; 15 Jul 26; 16:00) | Coherent Corp (COHR.K; US\$299.38; 1; 15 Jul 26; 16:00) | Keysight Technologies (KEYS.N; US\$322.71; 1; 15 Jul 26; 16:00) | Lumentum Holdings Inc (LITE.O; US\$752.0; 1; 15 Jul 26; 16:00)

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Appendix A-1

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